

Enlightenment Philosophy 1748

The Enlightenment was a movement of writers and thinkers, mostly in France, Britain, and their colonies, who argued that reason and observation — not tradition, divine right, or inherited privilege — should be the basis for organizing government and society. Two texts published within this project's timeframe supplied the specific political vocabulary that revolutionaries would later use to justify overthrowing monarchies: Montesquieu's *The Spirit of the Laws* (1748) and Rousseau's *The Social Contract* (1762).

Montesquieu, studying the English constitutional system after the Glorious Revolution of 1688, argued that liberty is best protected when governmental power is divided among separate branches — legislative, executive, and judicial — each able to check the others. His central claim, drawn from observing how unchecked monarchs like Louis XIV had ruled France, was that concentrating all power in one person or body inevitably leads to tyranny, regardless of that ruler's intentions. Rousseau, writing fourteen years later, went further: he argued that government has no legitimate authority except what the governed consent to give it, an idea he called the "general will." A king who ruled without the people's consent was, in Rousseau's framework, not a legitimate authority at all — merely a person exercising force.

These were not abstract classroom exercises. Thomas Jefferson had a French edition of Montesquieu on his shelf while drafting the Declaration of Independence in 1776, and the U.S. Constitution's division into Congress, the Presidency, and the Supreme Court is a direct, traceable application of Montesquieu's separation-of-powers argument. The French National Assembly's 1789 Declaration of the Rights of Man cites "the distinction of powers" by name as a requirement for any constitution. In Saint-Domingue (Haiti), enslaved and free Black revolutionaries led by Toussaint Louverture invoked the same language of natural rights and popular sovereignty against French colonial rule after 1791, applying Enlightenment consent theory to a population its French originators had not imagined including.

The problem-solving application for a student of this era is diagnostic: when analyzing any revolution or constitutional document from 1776 onward, ask two questions drawn directly from these texts — does power get divided or checked (Montesquieu's test), and does the government's authority derive from the consent of the governed (Rousseau's test)? Regimes

that failed both tests — Bourbon France, the Spanish Bourbon monarchy in Latin America, the Russian and Ottoman empires — became the recurring targets of nineteenth-century liberal and nationalist uprisings.

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